STRICTLY BUSINESS CONFIDENTIAL

Partnership Proposal for Saudi Arabian Scientific Journal Development and Indexing Excellence

July 2025

WARAQA

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Strategy · Communications · Engagement

A Strategic Partnership Proposal for the Saudi Arabian Ministry of Education submitted by Waraqa Publishing House (Dr. Theeb Ayedh Alkahtani, Founder and Chairman) and Inspiring STEM Consulting (Martin Delahunty, Founder and Director)

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1. Introduction and Response to Ministry Request

1.1 Context and Ministry of Education Requirements

Following productive discussions between Dr. Theeb Ayedh Alkahtani, Founder and Chairman of Waraqa Publishing House, and senior representatives from the Saudi Arabian Ministry of Education, this proposal directly addresses the Ministry's identified strategic requirements for transforming the Kingdom's scientific publishing landscape.

The Ministry of Education has completed a comprehensive national assessment of Saudi Arabia's scientific publishing ecosystem and identified a critical two-tier opportunity requiring immediate strategic intervention:

Tier 1: Priority Journal Development

- 15 high-potential journals with established author communities, institutional support, and strong potential for international indexing in ISI (Web of Science) and PubMed databases
- These journals require intensive, specialized development to achieve Quartile 1 status in international rankings

Tier 2: Broader Arabic-Language Publishing Infrastructure

- Hundreds of Arabic-language scientific journals currently lacking basic publishing infrastructure and international standards
- These publications require systematic development toward proper indexing and international recognition

1.2 Strategic Alignment with Vision 2030

This initiative directly supports Saudi Arabia's Vision 2030 transformation objectives by:

- Establishing Knowledge Economy Leadership**:** Positioning the Kingdom as the Middle East's premier scientific publishing hub
- Enhancing International Research Reputation**:** Elevating Saudi journals to global recognition through Quartile 1 achievements
- Building Sustainable Research Infrastructure**:** Creating self-sustaining publishing ecosystems requiring minimal long-term external support
- Supporting Economic Diversification**:** Developing knowledge-based industries and attracting international research collaborations

1.3 Ministry's Two-Part Strategic Requirements

Based on the Ministry's assessment and strategic planning discussions, this proposal addresses two distinct but complementary program components:

Strategic Advisory Engagement

The Ministry has requested comprehensive consulting services to guide the entire Saudi journal development process, including:

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- Governance & Editorial Structures**:** Establishing world-class editorial frameworks and management systems
- Quality and Transparency Improvements**:** Implementing international best practices and ethical standards
- Global Indexing Requirements: Navigating complex Web of Science, PubMed, and Scopus criteria
- Policy Alignment**:** Ensuring full compliance with COPE, ICMJE, and other international publishing standards

Indexing & Journal Transformation Program

The Ministry seeks a specialized program to transform the 15 selected high-potential journals through:

- Citation Analysis & Benchmarking**:** Comprehensive assessment and competitive positioning analysis
- Editorial Workflow Enhancement**:** Modern manuscript management and peer review optimization
- Metadata Structuring & Visibility Optimization**:** International discovery and indexing preparation
- Training for Editors and Reviewers**:** Capacity building for sustainable excellence
- Full Roadmap Implementation**:** Systematic progression toward Web of Science and PubMed indexing

1.4 Unique Value Proposition of Our Partnership

Our consortium brings together the optimal combination of local expertise and international excellence required for successful implementation:

Waraqa Publishing House provides:

- Deep understanding of the Saudi research ecosystem and regional academic contexts
- Established relationships with Saudi institutions, researchers, and funding bodies
- Cultural expertise ensuring respectful integration of Arabic-language publishing traditions
- Local regulatory knowledge and government partnership experience

Inspiring STEM Consulting delivers:

- Over 35 years of international publishing transformation experience
- Proven track record with leading publishers including Elsevier, Springer Nature, and Thomson Science
- Specialized expertise in journal citation growth strategies (25% JIF improvements within 24 months)
- Leadership experience in developing Nature Partner Journals and other high-impact publications

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1.5 Revolutionary Approach: Integrated Solutions

This proposal presents the most comprehensive journal development initiative ever undertaken in the Middle East, featuring five integrated strategic components:

1. Strategic Advisory Engagement (Years 1-5): Continuous expert guidance and international standards implementation
2. Advanced Citation Growth Strategy (Years 1-5): Sophisticated methodologies targeting Quartile 1 achievement for 80% of selected journals
3. Saudi Arabian Preprint Repository (Years 1-5): Innovative content pipeline using ScienceOpen's proven platform
4. 15 Selected Journals Transformation Program **(**Years 1-3): Intensive development using Clarivate evaluation criteria
5. Broader Arabic-Language Journals Development Program (Years 2-5): Scalable framework for regional publishing excellence

1.6 Ambitious Yet Achievable Goals

Primary Objective**:** Elevate 80% of the 15 selected Saudi journals to Quartile 1 status in both Journal Impact Factor (Clarivate) and CiteScore (Scopus) within 5 years.

Secondary Objectives**:**

- Establish sustainable publishing infrastructure for hundreds of Arabic-language journals
- Position Saudi Arabia as the Middle East's leading scientific publishing hub
- Create self-sustaining citation growth patterns requiring minimal long-term intervention
- Build comprehensive local capacity for independent journal management

1.7 Investment and Strategic Value

Total Investment**:** $6.78 million over five years represents value for achieving international Quartile 1 recognition while building comprehensive regional publishing infrastructure.

1.8 Commitment to Research Integrity

In response to recent challenges in Saudi research reputation, our approach prioritizes research integrity above all metrics, implementing:

- Zero-tolerance policies for publication misconduct
- Comprehensive COPE and ICMJE compliance across all participating journals
- Ethical citation practices with strict self-citation monitoring
- Transparent quality assurance with continuous improvement protocols

1.9 Proposal Structure and Implementation

This proposal outlines:

- Detailed implementation methodology for both Ministry requirements
- Comprehensive financial framework with clear value propositions
- Rigorous success metrics and performance monitoring systems
- Risk management strategies ensuring sustainable outcomes
- Long-term sustainability planning for eventual independence

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2. Leadership Team and Expertise

2.1 Dr. Theeb Ayedh Alkahtani, MD MBE

Founder and Chairman, Waraqa Publishing House | CEO, NAMA CRO

Dr. Alkahtani is a visionary leader combining clinical expertise with strategic business acumen to transform scientific publishing and research infrastructure in Saudi Arabia. As Founder and Chairman of Waraqa Publishing, he leads the development of Saudi Arabia's premier scientific publishing initiatives, while simultaneously serving as CEO of NAMA CRO, where he has orchestrated the company's rapid evolution from a specialized medical writing and bioequivalence company (established 2023) to a regional leader in Real-World Evidence clinical trials and comprehensive CRO services (2024).

Educational Background and Qualifications

- Doctor of Medicine (MD)**:** Clinical practice foundation providing deep understanding of research methodology and scientific rigor
- Master of Business Excellence (MBE)**:** Strategic business leadership expertise for scaling complex scientific enterprises

Professional Achievements

- Healthcare Innovation Leadership**:** Built Saudi Arabia's first Accountable Care Organization (ACO) and integrated health intelligence stack, demonstrating unprecedented capability in complex healthcare system integration
- Regulatory Excellence**:** Successfully navigated complex multi-agency regulatory environments across healthcare, research, and publishing sectors, including partnerships with SFDA, CHI, and SDAIA
- Sustainable Business Model Development**:** Created innovative business models that align profit with public benefit, ensuring long-term sustainability of scientific publishing initiatives
- Cross-Sector Partnership Orchestration: Established strategic partnerships across healthcare, technology, insurance, and academic sectors, building robust networks for collaborative research

Real-World Evidence Expertise

- 8-Layer Saudi Health Intelligence Stack: Development of comprehensive data harmonization platform integrating 25+ million patient records
- National Data Integration**:** Leadership in harmonizing real-world data across healthcare silos, creating unified evidence platforms for all stakeholders
- Evidence-Based Policy Making**:** Collaboration with regulatory bodies using real-world evidence for policy development and regulatory decision making

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2.2 Martin Delahunty MBA

Founder and Director, Inspiring STEM Consulting

Martin Delahunty brings over 35 years of distinguished experience in scientific and medical publishing to the Saudi journal development initiative. As Founder and Director of Inspiring STEM Consulting, he provides specialized expertise in publishing strategy, business development, and training services for publishers, professional associations, pharmaceutical companies, and technology services worldwide. Martin has extensive leadership experience with the world's most prestigious scientific publishers, including: **Elsevier**: strategic development and international expansion initiatives, **Harcourt**: publishing innovation and market development and **Thomson Science**: global publishing strategy and technology integration.

Development of Saudi Arabian journals

During the period 2014-17, Martin was Global Director for the Nature Partner Journals successfully launching two Nature-branded journals in partnership with King Abdulaziz University and one with King Fahd University of Petroleum & Minerals. All journals are now ranked in the top quartiles of their respective Journal Citation Categories.

Specialized Expertise

- Open Science Publishing Principles**:** Leading advocate and implementer of open access models and transparent research dissemination
- Technological Innovation: Pioneer in publishing workflow innovations, including the responsible implementation of artificial intelligence tools in editorial processes
- Citation Growth Strategies**:** Proven track record in developing and implementing strategies that significantly improve journal impact factors and citation metrics
- International Standards Implementation**:** Deep expertise in COPE, ICMJE, and other international publishing standards

Professional Organization Leadership

- Former Secretary**:** International Society for Medical Publication Professionals (ISMPP), demonstrating commitment to global publishing excellence
- Current President: European Medical Writers Association (EMWA), providing leadership in professional development and standards
- Advisory Roles: Multiple advisory positions with international publishing organizations and standards bodies

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3. Strategic Approach

3.1 Challenge

Saudi Arabia's scientific research output has grown dramatically, yet its journals remain largely invisible in international rankings. Recent research integrity concerns have limited international collaboration, and fragmented publication standards have created both challenges and unprecedented opportunities for transformation. With Vision 2030's emphasis on knowledge economy development and the Ministry's commitment to journal excellence, the timing is optimal for establishing Saudi Arabia as the Middle East's premier scientific publishing hub.

3.2 Vision & Goals

The Kingdom of Saudi Arabia stands at a transformative moment in its scientific publishing evolution. Building on the Ministry of Education's strategic assessment to identify 15 high-potential journals for international indexing, we propose the most comprehensive journal development initiative ever undertaken in the Middle East. Our consortium combines proven international expertise with deep local knowledge to deliver an ambitious yet achievable goal, that of elevating 80% of selected Saudi journals to Quartile 1 status in both Journal Impact Factor (Clarivate) and CiteScore (Scopus) within 5 years**.**

3.3 Our Transformative Solution

We will deliver the following five integrated components as part of a comprehensive strategy:

Component	Deliverable
1. **Strategic Advisory Engagement** (Years 1-5)	• Continuous expert guidance on governance, editorial structures, and international standards alignment
2. **Advanced Citation Growth Strategy** (Years 1-5)	• Sophisticated methodologies proven to achieve 25% Journal Impact Factor increases within 2 years
3. **Saudi Arabian Preprint Repository** (Years 1-5)	• Dedicated platform for open peer review and high-quality content pipeline development
4. **15 Selected Journals Transformation Program** (Years 1-3)	• Intensive development using Clarivate Web of Science evaluation criteria
5. Broader Arabic-Language Journals Development Program (Years 2-5)	• Scalable framework for hundreds of regional journals

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3.4 Proven Citation Growth Methodology

Our evidence-based approach targets specific drivers that directly impact rankings:

- **High-Impact Author Acquisition**: Systematic recruitment of globally recognized researchers through personalized outreach and incentive programs, leveraging proven strategies that have delivered 25% JIF improvements within 24 months.
- **Strategic Content Optimization**: Implementation of review article strategies (generating 40-60% more citations), special issue development (30-40% citation increase), and zero-citation article elimination through predictive analytics.
- **International Network Building**: Establishment of robust citation networks through editorial board enhancement, international collaborations, and strategic partnerships with leading global institutions.

3.5 Rigorous Journal Selection Process

Our selection methodology for identifying the 15 high-potential journals directly aligns with Clarivate Web of Science's 28 evaluation criteria, ensuring chosen journals have maximum advancement potential:

Focus Area	Evaluation Criteria
Phase 1: Comprehensive landscape assessment with initial triage alignment	• Valid ISSN registration • Established publisher verification • Accessible journal website • Evidence of peer review policies • Minimum 24-month publication history
Phase 2: Editorial standards evaluation matching Web of Science requirements	• Scholarly content quality • English-language capabilities • Bibliographic excellence • Editorial clarity and transparency • Publication timeliness • Ethics integration
Phase 3: Advanced quality assessment using 24 quality criteria	• Editorial board excellence (40% international) • Peer review robustness • Content relevance and scope alignment • Community standards adherence • Author geographic diversity (30% international) • Citation quality assessment
Phase 4: Impact potential analysis using 4 impact criteria	• Current citation performance • Citation growth trajectory • Author network strength • Subject category competitiveness

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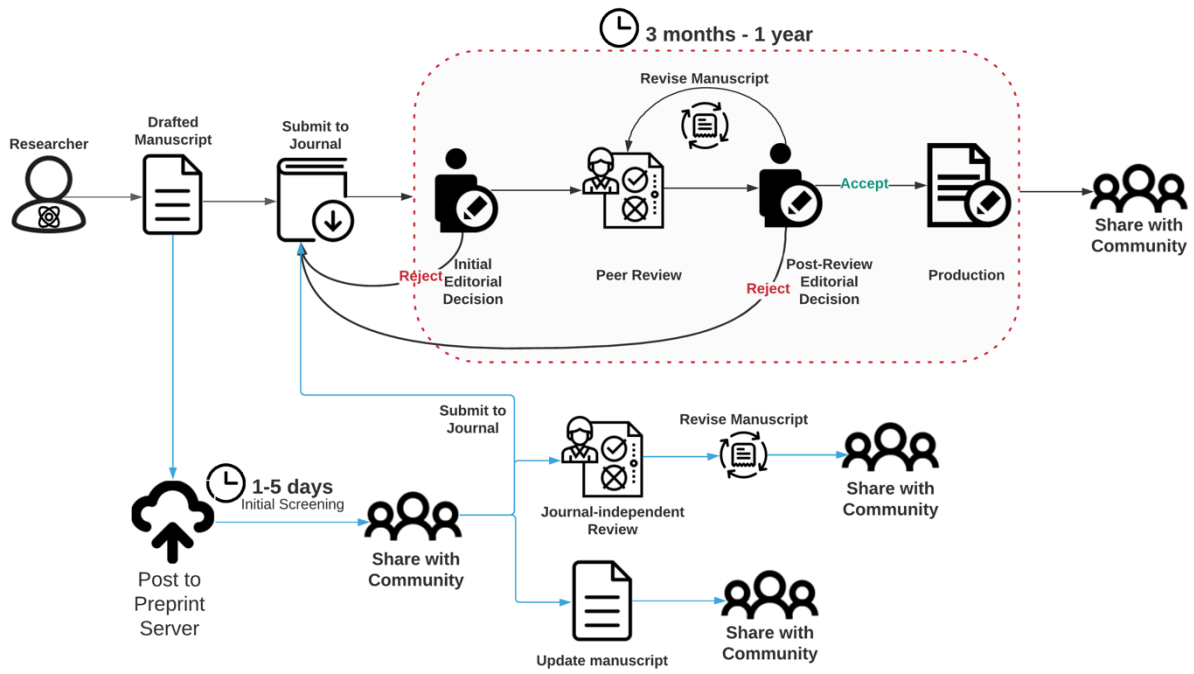
3.6 Ambitious Yet Achievable Targets

Year	Primary Focus	Key Metrics	Target Achievements
1	Foundation establishment	International editorial boards	50% improvement in international editorial board representation
2	Citation growth acceleration	Strategic content development	40-60% citation growth with strategic special issues
3	Journal Impact Factor improvement	Substantial ranking advancement	75-100% Journal Impact Factor improvement with 50% achieving Q2+ status
4	Quartile 1 breakthrough	Premium ranking achievement	60% achieving Quartile 1 status in at least one ranking system
5	Quartile 1 dominance	Complete transformation	80% achieving Quartile 1 status in both JIF and CiteScore databases

3.7 Launch of National Preprint Repository



Research reputation plays a fundamental role at individual, institutional, and national levels in establishing credibility and fostering international collaboration. The Kingdom of Saudi Arabia stands at a pivotal moment to transform its research publishing landscape and establish itself as a global leader in research integrity and scientific excellence.

Our proposed journal development initiative directly addresses the Ministry's vision for rebuilding and enhancing Saudi Arabia's research reputation through a revolutionary content pipeline approach that strategically channels the highest-quality research to the 15 selected priority journals.

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Strategic Content Pipeline: Preprint Repository as Quality Filter

The centrepiece of our research integrity framework is the launch of a Saudi Arabian Preprint Repository, powered by ScienceOpen and which serves as an intelligent filter and content channel for the 15 high-potential journals:

- **AI-Driven Pre-Screening:** Every manuscript undergoes automated quality assessment and plagiarism detection before entering the repository, ensuring only legitimate research proceeds
- **Open Peer Review Validation:** Community-driven review process provides transparent quality evaluation, allowing journal editors to identify the most promising research
- **Content Quality Curation:** Journal editors gain access to a curated pool of pre-reviewed, community-validated manuscripts with demonstrated research integrity
- **Citation Potential Identification:** Preprints that generate significant community engagement and positive reviews are directly channelled to appropriate priority journals

Competitive Advantage for the 15 Selected Journals

This innovative content pipeline provides unprecedented advantages for achieving Quartile 1 status:

- **Higher Quality Submissions:** Journal editors receive manuscripts that have already undergone rigorous pre-screening and community validation
- **Reduced Editorial Burden:** Pre-reviewed content requires less initial assessment, allowing editors to focus on the highest-potential research
- **Enhanced Citation Prospects:** Manuscripts with strong community engagement in the preprint phase demonstrate higher citation potential
- **International Visibility:** Global discovery through ScienceOpen's 100 million article network increases author attraction and research quality

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4. Components & Key Deliverables

Overview

Component	Primary Focus	Key Deliverables	Target Outcomes
1. Strategic Advisory Engagement	Continuous expert guidance and international standards implementation	• Governance & editorial structure development • COPE and ICMJE compliance training • Global indexing strategy roadmap • International partnership development	• World-class editorial frameworks • Full compliance with international standards • Successful Web of Science and PubMed applications • Robust global research networks
2. Advanced Citation Growth Strategy	Sophisticated methodologies targeting Quartile 1 achievement for 80% of selected journals	• High-impact author acquisition program • Special issue development (30-40% citation increase) • Review article strategy (40-60% more citations) • Digital visibility optimization • Citation growth analytics	• 25% JIF improvement within 24 months • 75-100% citation growth by Year 3 • 80% of journals achieving Q1 status by Year 5 • Self-sustaining citation networks
3. Saudi Arabian Preprint Repository	Innovative content pipeline using ScienceOpen's proven platform	• AI-driven quality assessment platform • Open peer review in Arabic and English • Global discovery integration • Pre-screened manuscript pipeline • Community validation system	• 12,532 preprint articles over 5 years • Enhanced international visibility • Quality content pipeline for journals • Regional research ecosystem development • Open science leadership model

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Component	Primary Focus	Key Deliverables	Target Outcomes
4. Total of 15 Selected Journals Transformation Program	Intensive development using Clarivate evaluation criteria	• Rigorous journal selection (Web of Science alignment) • Editorial workflow enhancement • Metadata structuring & visibility optimization • Comprehensive training programs • Quality assurance implementation	• 15 journals meeting Web of Science standards • Modern manuscript management systems • International editorial board enhancement • Accelerated publication workflows • Foundation for Q1 achievement
5. Broader Arabic-Language Journals Development Program	Scalable framework for regional publishing excellence	• Bilingual publishing platform development • Technical standards framework • Centralized support services • Regional capacity building • Cultural localization protocols	• Infrastructure for hundreds of journals • Consistent quality standards • Regional publishing ecosystem • Cultural preservation with international standards • Middle East publishing hub establishment

Strategic Integration Benefits

Cross-Component Synergies	Description
Content Pipeline Integration	Preprint repository feeds high-quality, pre-reviewed manuscripts to the 15 selected journals
Citation Network Amplification	Advisory engagement and citation growth strategy work together to build robust international networks
Quality Assurance Consistency	Standards developed for priority journals cascade to broader Arabic-language program
Training and Capacity Building	Expertise developed in intensive program extends to regional journal development
Technology Platform Sharing	Infrastructure investments benefit both priority journals and broader regional development

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Phase-Based Implementation Timeline

Phase	Years	Active Components	Key Milestones
Foundation	1	1, 2, 3, 4	• Baseline assessment complete • Preprint repository launched • Editorial boards enhanced • Training programs initiated
Acceleration	2	All 5	• Citation growth demonstrable • Arabic platform development • Special issues launched • International partnerships established
Optimization	3	All 5	• Q2+ status achieved (50% of journals) • Regional framework operational • Sustainability planning initiated • Quality standards internalized
Achievement	4	1, 2, 3, 5	• Q1 status achieved (60% of journals) • Regional leadership established • Independent operations transition • International recognition secured
Sustainability	5	1, 2, 3, 5	• Q1 dominance (80% of journals) • Self-sustaining systems • Regional hub status • Global recognition achieved

Investment Distribution by Component

Component	Percentage of Total Investment	ROI Indicators
Strategic Advisory Engagement	20.9%	International standards compliance, global networks
Advanced Citation Growth Strategy	13.7%	Quartile 1 achievement, citation growth metrics
Saudi Arabian Preprint Repository	8.1%	Content quality pipeline, regional visibility
15 Selected Journals Transformation	17.0%	Web of Science readiness, editorial excellence
Broader Arabic-Language Development	6.4%	Regional infrastructure, cultural preservation
Discovery STM Services	33.9%	Production quality, technical excellence
TOTAL	100%	Complete transformation ecosystem

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Success Metrics by Component

Component	Year 1 Targets	Year 3 Targets	Year 5 Targets
Strategic Advisory	100% COPE/ICMJE compliance	Web of Science applications submitted	Independent operation capability
Citation Growth	25% JIF improvement baseline	75-100% citation increase	80% Q1 achievement
Preprint Repository	539 articles, platform launch	2,500 articles, community engagement	5,059 articles, regional leadership
15 Journals Program	Editorial enhancement complete	50% achieving Q2+ status	Foundation for sustained excellence
Arabic Development	Framework design	Regional platform operational	Hundreds of journals supported

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5. Journal Selection Process

Our selection methodology directly aligns with Clarivate Web of Science's 28 evaluation criteria, ensuring chosen journals have maximum advancement potential:

5.1 Four-Phase Selection

Focus Area	Evaluation Criteria	Key Activities	Selection Threshold	Expected Outcome
Phase 1: Comprehensive landscape assessment with initial triage alignment	• Valid ISSN registration • Established publisher verification • Accessible journal website • Evidence of peer review policies • Minimum 24-month publication history	• Complete Saudi journal inventory • Ministry database integration • Subject category mapping • Current status documentation	Basic eligibility requirements met	Qualified journal pool identified
Phase 2: Editorial standards evaluation matching Web of Science requirements	• Scholarly content quality • English-language capabilities • Bibliographic excellence • Editorial clarity and transparency • Publication timeliness • Ethics integration	• Content quality verification • Language standards assessment • Reference formatting evaluation • Editorial process review • Website functionality check	Web of Science editorial triage standards	Journals meeting international baseline standards
Phase 3: Advanced quality assessment using 24 quality criteria	• Editorial board excellence (40% international) • Peer review robustness • Content relevance and scope alignment • Community standards adherence • Author geographic diversity (30% international) • Citation quality assessment	• Board composition analysis • Review process evaluation • Content distribution assessment • COPE/ICMJE compliance verification • Quality control mechanism review	70/100 points (70% weight in scoring matrix)	High-quality journals with strong editorial foundations
Phase 4: Impact potential analysis using 4 impact criteria	• Current citation performance • Citation growth trajectory • Author network strength • Subject category competitiveness	• Comparative citation analysis • Historical growth assessment • Author h-index evaluation • Competitive landscape mapping • Collaboration potential review	30/100 points (30% weight in scoring matrix)	Journals with highest Q1 advancement potential

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5.2 Selection Scoring Matrix

Evaluation Component	Maximum Points	Weight	Minimum Threshold	Target Range
Quality Criteria (Phase 3)	70 points	70%	50 points	55-65 points
Impact Potential (Phase 4)	30 points	30%	20 points	23-28 points
TOTAL MAXIMUM SCORE	100 points	100%	75 points	80-95 points

5.3 Selection Thresholds and Targets

Score Range	Classification	Selection Decision	Expected Q1 Potential
90-100 points	Excellence Tier	Automatic selection	Very high (>80% probability)
80-89 points	Target Range	Priority selection	High (60-80% probability)
75-79 points	Threshold Range	Conditional selection	Moderate (40-60% probability)
Below 75 points	Below Threshold	Not selected	Low (<40% probability)

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6. Project Targets & Metrics

6.1 Year-by-Year Progression

Year	Primary Focus	Key Metrics	Target Achievements	Success Indicators
1	Foundation establishment	International editorial boards	50% improvement in international editorial board representation	• Enhanced global expertise • Improved peer review quality • Expanded research networks • Baseline infrastructure established
2	Citation growth acceleration	Strategic content development	40-60% citation growth with strategic special issues	• Measurable citation increases • High-impact special issues launched • Review article strategy implemented • International author engagement
3	Journal Impact Factor improvement	Substantial ranking advancement	75-100% Journal Impact Factor improvement with 50% achieving Q2+ status	• Dramatic citation growth demonstrated • 50% journals reach upper quartiles • International recognition established • Quality standards internalized
4	Quartile 1 breakthrough	Premium ranking achievement	60% achieving Quartile 1 status in at least one ranking system	• Majority reach top quartile • Sustained growth patterns • Regional leadership established • Operational independence developed
5	Quartile 1 dominance	Complete transformation	80% achieving Quartile 1 status in both JIF and CiteScore databases	• Q1 dominance across ranking systems • Self-sustaining excellence • Global recognition achieved • Regional hub status established

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6.2 Progressive Achievement Metrics

Achievement Level	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3	Year 4	Year 5
Editorial Excellence	50% international boards	Enhanced global representation	World-class composition	Leading international experts	Regional editorial leadership
Citation Performance	Baseline establishment	40-60% growth acceleration	75-100% JIF improvement	Sustained growth patterns	Consistent Q1 performance
Ranking Achievement	Foundation building	Upward movement initiated	50% achieve Q2+ status	60% achieve Q1 status	80% achieve Q1 status
International Recognition	Infrastructure development	Quality improvements visible	Regional recognition	International awards consideration	Global publishing hub status
Operational Capability	System implementation	Process optimization	Quality standards mastery	Independent operation readiness	Complete self-sufficiency

6.3 Cumulative Impact Trajectory

Metric	Baseline	Year 2 Target	Year 3 Target	Year 4 Target	Year 5 Target
Journals in Q1 Status	0	0-2 journals	2-4 journals	9 journals (60%)	12 journals (80%)
Average JIF Improvement	0%	40-60%	75-100%	125-150%	150-200%
International Editorial Board %	Current baseline	50% minimum	60% minimum	70% minimum	75% minimum
International Author %	Current baseline	30% minimum	40% minimum	50% minimum	60% minimum
Special Issues per Journal	0-1	2-3	3-4	4+	4+ (self-sustaining)

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7. Financial Investment (SAR)

SERVICES	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3	Year 4	Year 5	Total
Strategic Consulting (Years 1-5)						
Waraqa Publishing	337,500	346,875	356,250	365,625	375,000	1,781,250
Inspiring STEM Consulting	337,500	346,875	356,250	365,625	375,000	1,781,250
Journal Editor Training and Capacity Building	375,000	300,000	225,000	150,000	112,500	1,162,500
International Partnership Development	187,500	150,000	112,500	75,000	56,250	581,250
Subtotal	*1,237,500*	*1,143,750*	*1,050,000*	*956,250*	*918,750*	*5,306,250*
Advanced Citation Growth Strategy						
Citation Analysis & Benchmarking	112,500	93,750	75,000	56,250	46,875	384,375
High-Impact Author Acquisition	187,500	168,750	150,000	131,250	112,500	750,000
Special Issue Development	140,625	164,063	187,500	164,063	140,625	796,875
Review Article Strategy	93,750	112,500	131,250	112,500	93,750	543,750
Digital Visibility Optimization	75,000	93,750	112,500	93,750	75,000	450,000
International Collaboration Networks	56,250	75,000	93,750	75,000	56,250	356,250
Citation Growth Technology & Tools	37,500	42,188	46,875	42,188	37,500	206,250
Subtotal	*703,125*	*750,000*	*796,875*	*675,000*	*562,500*	*3,487,500*
Selected Journals Transformation Program						
Editorial Workflow Enhancement	187,500	187,500	93,750	0	0	468,750
Metadata & Visibility Optimization	187,500	187,500	93,750	0	0	468,750
Subtotal	*375,000*	*375,000*	*187,500*	*0*	*0*	*937,500*
Editorial and Production Services						
Platform, Hosting & Editorial Support	337,500	354,375	372,094	390,698	410,233	1,864,901
Editorial Admin & Coordination	225,000	236,250	248,063	260,466	273,489	1,243,267
Technical editing, XMP typesetting (15 journals)	2,250,000	2,362,500	2,480,625	2,604,656	2,734,889	12,432,670
Subtotal	*2,812,500*	*2,953,125*	*3,100,781*	*3,255,820*	*3,418,611*	*15,540,838*
Saudi Arabian Preprint Repository (ScienceOpen)						
Build Cost	75,000	0	0	0	0	75,000
Site Navigation Adaptation for Arabic	26,250	0	0	0	0	26,250
Annual Maintenance	43,125	43,125	43,125	43,125	43,125	215,625
Annual Customisation Budget	18,750	18,750	18,750	18,750	18,750	93,750
Outreach & Engagement	3,750	3,750	3,750	3,750	3,750	18,750
Pre-publication Checks / SciScore	6,064	11,831	20,768	32,411	47,430	118,504
Oversight/Quality Assurance	10,106	23,663	41,531	64,819	94,856	234,975
Post Publication Services/Indexing	50,531	118,313	207,656	324,094	474,281	1,174,875
Customer Service	18,000	18,000	18,000	18,000	18,000	90,000
Subtotal	*251,576*	*237,431*	*353,580*	*504,949*	*700,193*	*2,047,729*
Broader Arabic-Language Journals Development						
Platform Development	0	281,250	187,500	140,625	93,750	703,125
Localization Services	0	150,000	112,500	75,000	56,250	393,750
Journal Editor Training and Support	0	187,500	150,000	112,500	75,000	525,000
Subtotal	*0*	*618,750*	*450,000*	*328,125*	*225,000*	*1,621,875*
GRAND TOTAL	**5,379,701**	**6,078,056**	**5,938,736**	**5,720,144**	**5,825,054**	**28,941,692**

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8. Success Metrics and Expected Outcomes

8.1 Achievement Targets Summary

Key Metric	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3	Year 4	Year 5
Primary Focus	Foundation & Assessment	Growth Acceleration	Substantial Improvement	Q1 Breakthrough	Q1 Dominance
Journal Impact Factor	Baseline establishment	25-40% improvement	75-100% improvement	Sustained growth	Q1 achievement (80% of journals)
Quartile Rankings	Current status mapping	Upward movement (30%)	Q2+ status (50%)	Q1 status (60%)	Q1 status (80%)
Editorial Excellence	50% international representation	Enhanced global boards	World-class composition	Leading experts	Regional leadership
Content Strategy	30% review article increase	20-25% review content	High-quality reviews	Premium content	Industry-leading articles
International Networks	25% author increase	40% co-authorship growth	Robust global networks	Established collaborations	Self-sustaining networks

8.2 Key Performance Indicators with Measurable Targets

Metric	Year 1 Target	Year 2 Target	Year 3 Target	Year 4 Target	Year 5 Target
Journal Impact Factor	Baseline establishment	25-40% improvement	75-100% improvement	Sustained growth	Q1 achievement (80% of journals)
CiteScore Metrics	Baseline establishment	30-50% improvement	70-90% improvement	Consistent growth	Q1 achievement (80% of journals)
Quartile Rankings	Current status mapping	Upward movement (30% of journals)	Q2+ status (50% of journals)	Q1 status (60% of journals)	Q1 status (80% of journals)
International Editorial Board	50% improvement	Sustained enhancement	Global representation	World-class composition	Leading international experts

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Metric	Year 1 Target	Year 2 Target	Year 3 Target	Year 4 Target	Year 5 Target
Review Article Content	30% increase in submissions	20-25% of total content	Sustained high-quality reviews	Premium review content	Industry-leading review articles
International Authors	25% increase	40% co-authorship increase	Robust global networks	Established collaborations	Self-sustaining networks

9. Implementation Timeline

9.1 Overview

Year/Phase	Focus Area	Key Activities	Deliverables	Success Metrics
Year 1: Foundation and Assessment	Program Launch	• Strategic partnership agreements finalization • Initial assessment of 15 selected journals • Editorial board recruitment and training initiation • Technical infrastructure development	• Signed partnership agreements • Comprehensive journal assessment reports • Enhanced editorial boards (50% international) • Technical platform specifications	• 15 journals assessed • Editorial board international representation >50% • Infrastructure roadmap approved
	Systems Implementation	• Manuscript management system deployment • Initial editorial workflow optimization • COPE and ICMJE compliance training • First-phase indexing applications	• Operational manuscript systems • Optimized editorial workflows • Ethics compliance certification • Web of Science application submissions	• 100% COPE/ICMJE compliance • Reduced processing times by 30% • Indexing applications submitted

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Year/Phase	Focus Area	Key Activities	Deliverables	Success Metrics
Year 2: Transformation and Scaling	Process Optimization	• Editorial workflow refinement • Peer review quality enhancement • Citation analysis and benchmarking • Arabic-language platform development	• Refined editorial processes • Enhanced peer review systems • Citation baseline reports • Bilingual platform prototype	• 25% JIF improvement baseline • Peer review quality scores >4.0/5 • Arabic platform beta launch
	Expansion Phase	• Additional journal onboarding • International partnership development • First indexing achievements • Training program scaling	• Expanded journal portfolio • International collaboration agreements • Initial indexing successes • Scaled training infrastructure	• 40% increase in international authors • First ESCI indexing achieved • 200+ trained editors/reviewers
Year 3: Consolidation and Growth	Impact Measurement	• Citation impact assessment • Indexing status review • Quality metrics evaluation • Success story documentation	• Citation growth reports • Indexing progress analysis • Quality assessment dashboard • Success case studies	• 75-100% citation increase • 50% of journals achieve Q2+ status • Quality metrics >90% targets
	Sustainability Planning	• Long-term financial modelling • Local capacity handover planning • Continuous improvement protocols • International recognition enhancement	• Financial sustainability models • Capacity transfer roadmaps • Quality improvement frameworks • International recognition strategy	• Financial independence pathway • Local expertise development • International awards/recognition

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Year/Phase	Focus Area	Key Activities	Deliverables	Success Metrics
Year 4: Achievement and Independence	Advanced Optimization	• Independent operation transition • Regional leadership establishment • Citation network consolidation	• Independent operational capability • Advanced citation strategies • Regional hub establishment • Robust citation networks	• 60% of journals achieve Q1 status • Independent operation capability • Regional leadership recognition
Year 5: Excellence and Sustainability	Global Recognition	• Global recognition achievement • Self-sustaining systems implementation • Knowledge transfer completion • Future strategy development	• Global recognition achievement • Self-sustaining operational systems • Complete knowledge transfer • 5-year strategic plan	• 80% of journals achieve Q1 status • Self-sustaining operations • Global publishing hub status

9.2 Critical Milestones and Dependencies

Milestone	Target	Dependencies	Risk Mitigation
Partnership Agreements Signed	Q1 Year 1	Ministry approval, legal frameworks	Early stakeholder engagement, legal preparation
Editorial Boards Enhanced	Q2 Year 1	International expert recruitment	Global network activation, competitive packages
Systems Operational	Q4 Year 1	Technical development, training completion	Phased deployment, comprehensive testing
Citation Growth Demonstrated	Q2 Year 2	Content strategy implementation	Multiple citation drivers, performance monitoring
First Indexing Success	Q4 Year 2	Quality standards achievement	Rigorous preparation, expert guidance
Regional Platform Launch	Q1 Year 3	Arabic localization, content development	Cultural adaptation, community engagement
Financial Sustainability	Q4 Year 3	Revenue model implementation	Diversified funding, cost optimization
Q1 Achievement (60%)	Q4 Year 4	Sustained citation growth	Continuous optimization, quality maintenance
Complete Independence	Q4 Year 5	Knowledge transfer, capability building	Systematic handover, ongoing support

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9.3 Resource Allocation Timeline

Year	Primary Investment Focus	Resource Allocation	Expected ROI
Year 1	Foundation and Infrastructure	21.3% of total budget	Infrastructure establishment, baseline improvement
Year 2	Transformation and Scaling	22.1% of total budget	Measurable citation growth, international recognition
Year 3	Optimization and Growth	21.0% of total budget	Q2+ status achievement, regional leadership
Year 4	Achievement and Independence	17.4% of total budget	Q1 status majority, operational independence
Year 5	Excellence and Sustainability	18.2% of total budget	Q1 dominance, self-sustaining systems

10. Partnership Structure and Governance

10.1 Consortium Leadership

- Waraqa Publishing**:** Program leadership, local coordination, and Arabic-language expertise
- Inspiring STEM Consulting**:** International standards, strategic advisory, and indexing expertise

10.2 Ministry Integration

- Steering Committee**:** Joint governance with Ministry representatives
- Progress Reviews**:** Quarterly assessments and strategic adjustments
- Quality Assurance**:** Independent evaluation and continuous improvement
- Knowledge Transfer**:** Comprehensive documentation and training protocols

10.3 Academic Partnerships

- Editorial Boards**:** International recruitment and training
- Research Institutions**:** Formal collaboration agreements
- Professional Societies**:** Strategic partnerships and endorsements
- Funding Bodies**:** Alignment with research funding priorities

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11. Strategic Implementation and Vision Realization

11.1 Implementation Plan

The Saudi Arabian Ministry of Education's vision for scientific publishing excellence represents a transformative opportunity to establish the Kingdom as a global leader in research dissemination. Our partnership's proven methodologies, combined with specialized service providers and Saudi Arabia's commitment to Vision 2030, create the optimal conditions for achieving Quartile 1 journal rankings while maintaining the highest ethical standards.

Immediate Action Plan**:**

- Journal Selection Finalization**:** Complete evaluation using Web of Science alignment criteria
- Governance Structure Establishment**:** Joint steering committee with Ministry representatives
- Implementation Commencement**:** Immediate launch of baseline assessments and strategic planning
- International Partnership Activation**:** Engagement of global editorial board members and research networks

11.2 Vision 2030 Alignment and National Impact

This initiative directly contributes to Saudi Arabia's transformation into a knowledge-based economy by:

- Establishing Research Excellence**:** Creating internationally recognized platforms for Saudi scientific output
- Attracting Global Talent**:** Enhanced journal reputation drawing international researchers and collaborations
- Building Regional Leadership**:** Positioning Saudi Arabia as the Middle East's premier scientific publishing hub
- Fostering Innovation Ecosystem**:** Comprehensive infrastructure supporting research commercialization and knowledge transfer

11.3 Long-Term Transformation

By 2030, Saudi Arabia will host 12+ internationally recognized Quartile 1 journals from the 15 selected core journals, while simultaneously developing a comprehensive infrastructure supporting hundreds of Arabic-language journals throughout the region, serving as the Middle East's premier scientific publishing hub while contributing meaningfully to global knowledge advancement.

11.4 Commitment to Excellence

Our partnership commitment extends beyond achieving numerical targets to establishing Saudi Arabia as a model for:

- Research Integrity Leadership: Comprehensive ethical frameworks serving as regional standards
- Open Science Innovation**:** Balancing traditional publishing excellence with modern open access principles

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- Cultural Preservation**:** Respecting Arabic language and local academic traditions while achieving international recognition
- Sustainable Development**:** Creating self-sustaining systems requiring minimal long-term external support

12. Conclusion and Recommendation

12.1 Strategic Value of Our Consulting Partnership

Based on the comprehensive analysis presented in this proposal, we respectfully recommend that the Saudi Arabian Ministry of Education engage our consortium to deliver the transformative journal development services outlined above. Our partnership between Waraqa Publishing House and Inspiring STEM Consulting offers the Ministry an unparalleled combination of local expertise and international publishing excellence specifically designed to achieve the ambitious goal of elevating 80% of selected Saudi journals to Quartile 1 status within five years.

12.2 Key Consulting Recommendations

- **Immediate Strategic Advisory Engagement**: We recommend commencing with our five-year strategic advisory services to establish the foundational governance structures, international standards compliance, and citation growth methodologies that will ensure sustainable success. Our proven track record of achieving 25% Journal Impact Factor improvements within 24 months provides the Ministry with confidence in our evidence-based approach.
- **Systematic Implementation Approach**: Our phased implementation methodology, beginning with rigorous journal selection using Clarivate Web of Science criteria and progressing through comprehensive citation enhancement strategies, offers the Ministry a systematic pathway to international recognition while maintaining the highest research integrity standards.
- **Comprehensive Ecosystem Development**: Beyond individual journal transformation, our integrated approach including the Saudi Arabian Preprint Repository and broader Arabic-language journals development program positions the Kingdom to become the Middle East's premier scientific publishing hub, directly supporting Vision 2030 objectives.

12.3 Expected Consulting Outcomes

Through our recommended consulting engagement, the Ministry can expect:

- Immediate Impact**:** Foundation establishment and international editorial board enhancement within Year 1
- Measurable Progress**:** 40-60% citation growth acceleration and demonstrable ranking improvements by Year 2
- Substantial Achievement**:** 50% of journals reaching Q2+ status with 75-100% JIF improvements by Year 3
- Strategic Success**:** 60% achieving Quartile 1 status in at least one ranking system by Year 4
- Complete Transformation**:** 80% Quartile 1 achievement across both JIF and CiteScore databases by Year 5

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12.5 Next Steps

We recommend that the Ministry proceed with formal engagement of our consulting services to begin the immediate assessment and strategic planning phases that will ensure successful implementation of this transformative initiative. Our team stands ready to commence this partnership and deliver the comprehensive journal development services that will establish Saudi Arabia's position as a world-class scientific publishing leader.

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